CHAPTER 10

FROM THE BATTLEFIELD TO BOARDROOM: HOW TO MEASURE LEADER PERFORMANCE

Summary

In this chapter, we discuss how contextual factors affect leadership and leader outcomes, the importance of considering context when assessing leadership, and currently developed contextually conscious measurement techniques. Woven throughout this chapter will be discussion of how practitioners can successfully navigate the scientific literature to understand what is currently known about the role contextual factors play in leadership and leader outcomes and suggestions for how practitioners can select, leverage, and interpret measures based on contextual factors.

Chapter Outline

A Brief History of Contextual Leadership

Types of Contextual Factors

- High- Level Contextual Factors
- Low- Level Contextual Factors
- Summary of the Effects of Context

Context and Measurement

- Formative Assessment
- Summative and Comparative Assessment

Future Directions

Conclusion

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Understand that how contextual factors affect leadership and leader outcomes

2. Recognize the importance of context in assessing leadership

3. Be aware of contextually conscious measurement techniques

Personal Development Activities

Exercise 1. Consider a challenge you are facing in your current role. Journal about the challenge as if you are discussing it with a peer or friend. Then identify contextual factors that are involved in your current challenge and consider how you can adjust your behavior based on those factors.

Exercise 2. Think about a leader you have witnessed who was either struggling to succeed or was succeeding quite well. The leader can be you, someone you know, or even a character from a book or movie. Imagine what would have happened if that same leader faced a different set of contextual factors. What factors could have helped them succeed or hindered their success?

Exercise 3. Write down three typical behaviors that you show as a leader. For each behavior, write down when you think it is successful (in which situation, context, with whom). Write down three behaviors that you could develop or adopt to become a more effective leader. For each behavior write down who and what could help you develop it.

Exercise 4. Think about the characteristic of your own leadership of which you are most proud. For instance, perhaps you perform well under pressure, always communicate clearly, or are extremely good at giving credit to others when it is due. Consider how you developed or learned this characteristic. Did you develop it from school, training, or experience? Did you witness it in others and therefore adopt it? Do the same for the characteristic of your own leadership that you would most like to develop.

Exercise 4. Ask a friend or peer to tell you about a leadership challenge they are currently facing or have faced in the past. Ask them about any contextual factors that played a role in their experience and how they overcame or planned to overcome the challenge. How are the contextual challenges they face different from those you see in your own roles?

Exercise 5. Recall a leadership-related event that you experienced several years back, perhaps as long as five or ten years ago. What do you remember about the situation and your behavior? Now, recall a leadership-related event that happened recently, perhaps in the past couple of weeks. What do you remember about the situation and your behavior? Identify the factors that guide your recall of each situation. Which role do positive/ negative feelings or success/ failure play when you think of past events? Could they affect your view of your leadership behavior in the past?

Exercise 6. Conduct an internet search for some leadership assessments that are freely available. Complete the assessment and consider the feedback you receive. Can you use the information you gained to guide your own development as a leader?

Key Reading

Oc, B. (2018). Contextual leadership: A systematic review of how contextual factors shape leadership and its outcomes. *The Leadership Quarterly, 29*(1), 218– 235. https:// doi.org/ 10.1016/ j.lea qua.2017.12.004

Further Reading

Elson, B. (2021, March 31). The power of context in leadership. *Forbes*. https://www.forbes.com/councils/forbesbusinesscouncil/2021/03/31/the-power-of-context-in-leadership/

Fiedler, F. E., & Garcia, J. E. (1987). *New approaches to effective leadership: Cognitive resources and organizational performance.* John Wiley & Sons.

Mayo, T. (2007, July 24). Context-based leadership. *Harvard Business Review*. https://hbr.org/2007/07/contextbased-leadership-1